

THE HEALTH REGULATORY AGENCIES AS INSTRUMENTS FOR PROFESSIONAL HARMONY IN NIGERIA

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1.0 Introduction

The **Health Regulatory Agencies in Nigeria** refer to establishments under the supervision of the **Federal Ministry of Health (FMOH)**, established by **Decrees (now Acts of the Laws of the Federation of Nigeria)** to regulate and control the training and practice of various healthcare professions in all aspects.

Presently, there are **thirteen such agencies**:

- 1. Pharmacists Council of Nigeria (PCN)**
- 2. Medical and Dental Council of Nigeria (MDCN)**
- 3. Institute of Public Analysts of Nigeria (IPAN)**
- 4. Medical Laboratory Scientists Council of Nigeria (MLSCN)**
- 5. Nursing and Midwifery Council of Nigeria (NMCN)**
- 6. Institute of Chartered Chemists of Nigeria (ICCON)**
- 7. Dental Therapists Registration Board of Nigeria (DTRBN)**
- 8. Medical Rehabilitation Therapists Registration Board of Nigeria (MRTB)**
- 9. Optometrists and Dispensing Opticians Registration Board of Nigeria (ODORBN)**
- 10. Dental Technologists Registration Board of Nigeria (DTRBN)**
- 11. Radiographers Registration Board of Nigeria (RRBN)**
- 12. Health Record Officers Registration Board of Nigeria (HRORBN)**
- 13. Community Health Practitioners Registration Board of Nigeria (CHPRBN)**

Each of these Councils, Boards, or Institutes is **headed by a Registrar**, who serves as the **Chief Executive Officer (CEO)** and is **employed through formal recruitment procedures as a Public Officer of the Federal Republic of Nigeria (FRN)**.

All thirteen regulatory agencies have **Governing Councils or Boards**, composed of **distinguished professionals**. Each Board is **headed by a chairman appointed by the President, Commander-in-Chief of the Federal Republic of Nigeria**.

The **size of the Governing Councils or Boards** varies according to the establishing Act. The **Pharmacists Council of Nigeria (PCN)** has the **largest Governing Council with 63 members**, while the **Community Health Practitioners Registration Board of Nigeria (CHPRBN)** has the **smallest with 11 members**.

(Table 1): SIN INSTITUTION NO. OF GOVERNING COUNCIL MEMBERS

S/NO	Institution	No. Of Governing Council Members
	Pharmacists Council of Nigeria (PCN)	63
	Medical and Dental Council of Nigeria (MDCN)	61
	Institute of Public Analysts of Nigeria (IPAN)	20
	Medical Laboratory Scientists Council of Nigeria (MLSCN)	1
	Nursing and Midwifery Council of Nigeria	18
	Institute of Chartered Chemists of Nigeria	17
	Dental Therapists Registration Board of Nigeria (DTRBN)	17
	Medical Rehabilitation Therapists Registration Board of Nigeria (MRTB)	17
	Optometrists and Dispensing Opticians Registration Board of Nigeria (ODORBN)	15
	Dental Technologists Registration Board of Nigeria (DTRBN)	13
	Radiographers Registration Board of Nigeria (RRBN)	12
	Health Record Officers Registration Board of Nigeria (HRORBN)	12
	Community Health Practitioners Registration Board of Nigeria (CHPRBN)	11

These agencies are established to create regulations in accordance with the Acts that founded them. Their purpose is to define, advance, and regulate the training and practice of their respective professions.

2.0 Establishment of the Committee of Registrars of the Health Professions (CRHP)

August 19, 2004, is a landmark date for healthcare professionals in Nigeria and the West African region. On that day, the then Honourable Minister of Health, Professor Eytayo Lambo, inaugurated the CRHP. The committee's objectives are to:

- Raise the level of ethical conduct in healthcare delivery services in Nigeria.
- Set targets for efficient performance.
- Facilitate Continuing Professional Development (CPD) for health professions in Nigeria.
- Educate the public on health matters.
- Harmonize regulatory activities to ensure efficiency and effectiveness across the health sector.
- Act as a platform for achieving synergy in government healthcare efforts by harnessing the unique strengths of each profession.
- Foster unity and mutual respect among the health professions.

During the inauguration, Professor Lambo stated: “It is therefore heart-warming that the Registrars of all the regulatory bodies in the health sector are coming together under one umbrella. This is commendable and should be applauded. I want to urge you to use this Committee as a springboard to rejuvenate the team spirit that is fast fading away” (Lambo, 2004).

The expectations for the Registrars are enormous. They cannot work in isolation; effective regulation requires collaboration. By working together instead of in parallel, patients and healthcare systems benefit tremendously (CRHP, 2008).

The need for this collaboration was further emphasized by Prince Julius Adedusi-Adeluyi, a distinguished pharmacist and former Minister of Health, who chaired the CRHP's first workshop on July 29, 2008. He stated:

"There is an urgent need for a strong advocacy of harmony among members of the Healthcare team" (CRHP, 2008).

These statements from two former Ministers of Health underscore the relevance of the CRHP's mission.

3.0 Activities of the CRHP from Inception to Date

The CRHP members, all experienced in implementing their respective Councils' mandates, have actively pursued their objectives through various capacity-building activities designed to promote cohesion and harmony, especially in areas of potential overlap. Key activities include:

- **First Retreat (April 10-13, 2008, Asaba, Delta State):** Held in honor of Dr. Ronald Eyime, former Registrar of the Optometrists and Dispensing Opticians Board. The topic was "Brainstorming on Ways to Improve Health Care Delivery Services in Nigeria."
- **Second Retreat (Obudu Cattle Ranch, Calabar):** Featured Prof. W. O. Aiyepoku on "Empowering Knowledge Workers for Organizational Success: The Advantages of a Knowledge Management-Savvy Workforce."
- **Third Retreat (January 18-19, 2011, Yankari Game Reserve, Bauchi State):** Organized by GSCL Consulting on "The Need for Minimum Standard of Practice by Health Regulatory Agencies as an Instrument for Assuring Effective Health Care Regulation in Nigeria."
- **First Workshop (July 29, 2008, Sheraton Hotel, Abuja):** Theme: "The Role of Health Regulatory Bodies in Advancing Healthcare Delivery Services in Nigeria."
- **International Conference (February 18-19, 2010, Geneva, Switzerland):** Attendance at the Second World Health Professions Conference on Regulation, "Shaping the Future: The Regulation of Health Professionals."
- **International Training (March 14-25, 2011, Liverpool Hope University, UK):** A two-week Professional Development Programme in Strategic Development Policy.

These activities are essential because healthcare professions and their regulations are dynamic. This constant change necessitates measurable standards that Councils and Boards can use to evaluate the quality of the professions they regulate.

4.0 Lessons Learned

The primary aim of all regulatory bodies is to control the training and practice of their professions. Effective regulation improves patient health outcomes and strengthens the healthcare system. A key benefit is the enhancement of professional competencies through Continuing Professional Development (CPD) programs.

There are no quick fixes in healthcare. All health professionals are interdependent, and effective regulation recognizes this:

- A doctor needs accurate records from a Health Record Officer.
- A correct diagnosis depends on a Medical Laboratory Scientist's diligence.
- A ward nurse must be guided by a pharmacist in drug administration.
- Optometrists and Ophthalmologists must collaborate on patient care.
- A Radiographer's accurate interpretation is crucial for an Orthopaedic surgeon.
- Community Health Officers in rural areas make critical referral decisions.

This interdependence underscores why regulatory agencies themselves must collaborate. Having all health regulatory agencies headquartered in close proximity within the Federal Capital Territory (FCT), Abuja, would further cement professional harmony and facilitate cooperation.

5.0 Recommendations and Implementation Strategies

Recommendations:

1. The CRHP should continue to plan activities that foster unity among its members and prioritize patient interests.
2. The CRHP should establish a periodic forum with the Presidents of the various national health associations to improve understanding and advance healthcare delivery.

3. The Federal Government, through the Ministry of Health, should increase funding to health regulatory agencies to enable them to function effectively.
4. The Federal Capital Territory (FCT) should allocate land in Abuja to agencies still headquartered in Lagos, and the Federal Ministry of Finance should provide capital grants for building new headquarters.
5. The Federal Ministry of Health should continue its support for the CRHP and its member agencies.

Implementation Strategies:

- i. The CRHP will continue to organize workshops and retreats to entrench harmony.
- ii. The CRHP will contact the heads of national health associations to convene a collaborative meeting.
- iii. The Federal Ministry of Health will be advocated to for increased budgetary allocation to health regulatory agencies.
- iv. The Federal Government will be requested, via the FCT Administration and Ministry of Finance, to approve land and funds for Lagos-based agencies to relocate to Abuja.
- v. The Honourable Minister of Health will be encouraged to continue motivating the CRHP and its member Councils.

6.0 Conclusion

In conclusion, this presentation aligns with the Adair's model of leadership. Each health regulatory body must focus on three core areas:

- **Achieving the Task** of effective health regulation.
- **Building and Maintaining the Team** of healthcare professionals.
- **Developing the Individual** professional through CPD programs (Weir, 2011).

By effectively implementing these principles, the desired harmony among healthcare professionals will naturally follow.

Thank you for your attention.

References

CRHP (2008): *"The Role of Health Regulatory Bodies in Advancing Healthcare Delivery Services in Nigeria — Proceedings of a One-Day Advocacy Workshop"*, Ibadan.

Lambo, E. Prof (2004): *Address on the Formal Inauguration of the Committee of Registrars of the Health Professions (CRHP)*, August 19, 2004, Abuja.

Weir, D. (2011): *"Culture Diversity and Change Management in Public Services"*, presentation for CRHP at Liverpool Hope University, March 16, 2011.